

Saz on the Beach, in Morjim, as dusk falls; below left, vegan sandwich at Cafe We in Anjuna; centre, Khandvi Ravioli at Fig & Maple, Assagao; right, community meals at the Village Bistro at Arpora

SUN, SAND AND SMORGASBORD

How did Goa transform into the foodie capital of India and what culinary delights does it offer to the visitor?

By Joanna Lobo

On a quiet morning, while Goa sleeps, Shubhra Shankhwalker wakes up to make the 4 am trek to a manos (sluice gate) to pick up tiny prawns, locally called *manshechi sungta*. Fish sourced from the manos are tastier and, thus, precious. For Shankhwalker, going this extra mile is par for the course. The graphic designer and home chef is proud of her culinary heritage and the abundance of Goa's produce, and highlights both through her culinary venture, Aai's. A curated meal at her farm is a masterclass in the diversity of Goan produce.

Goa has always been a compelling culinary destination, but it took the pandemic for others to realise it. Post the 2020 lockdown, people flocked to Goa seeking a better quality of life, an exodus that impacted the state in many ways, and transformed the F&B space.

Three years on, what looked like a temporary fad is here to stay. Goa's culinary scene is turning heads. It is winning awards, attracting big hospitality brands, established and new chefs, and anyone with the dream of owning a restaurant/bar. Old Goan houses are finding new life as happening hubs. Temporary structures have come up overnight, offering Instagrammable corners and free wi-fi. Entire beachfronts like Morjim have turned into party spots. There are home chefs offering different cuisines. And, there are tour companies eager to respond to tourist demands for culinary experiences.

It is an exciting time to be a diner in Goa.



The right choice

Where to dine today? In Goa, this isn't an easy question. Customers have the burden of choice, with a new place opening every week (on average). Goa is the new hunting ground for existing players like Fig & Maple and Izumi (Assagao), Drinking Safari Pitstop (Calangute), Elephant & Co (Anjuna), Mamagoto

